1. Fondazione Meriggio: A Cultural Vision for the Present and the Future

Fondazione Meriggio is a non-profit cultural organization founded on the vision of **Denis Faccioli** and **Alessandra Pacilli**, with the aim of promoting art, culture, education, research, and dialogue as tools for individual and collective growth. Established in 2024, the Foundation represents the natural evolution of a journey that began several years earlier around Villa Meriggio and its cultural activities.

The belief at the heart of the project is simple: culture is not an accessory to society, but one of its fundamental infrastructures. It contributes to fostering a sense of belonging, critical thinking, social inclusion, and a shared vision of the future. For this reason, the Foundation invests in the promotion of art, education, environmental sustainability, research, and the enhancement of cultural heritage.

Since its inception, Fondazione Meriggio has chosen to operate as an independent institution capable of supporting and developing cultural projects that combine high quality standards with accessibility. Its activities include conferences, philosophical discussions, artistic programmes, literary events, educational initiatives, and collaborations with universities, artists, cultural institutions, and local associations.

One of the Foundation's defining characteristics is its family-led nature and its deep connection to the local area. The project was created by people who live in this territory, understand its history, opportunities, and challenges, and have chosen to invest directly in the cultural development of their community. This dimension allows the Foundation to preserve a strong sense of identity while avoiding approaches that are purely commercial or disconnected from local realities.

The Foundation also supports numerous external initiatives in the cultural, social, educational, and scientific fields. Support is directed toward projects that share values consistent with its mission and demonstrate a tangible capacity to generate value for the community. The selection process is guided not by visibility or convenience, but by the desire to contribute to a sustainable and widespread cultural ecosystem.

One of the Foundation's key priorities concerns younger generations. Fondazione Meriggio seeks to offer young people opportunities for encounter, dialogue, and personal growth that are often concentrated exclusively in major urban or university centres. For this reason, it promotes activities that encourage curiosity, critical thinking, and intellectual exploration, including philosophy, contemporary art, research, literature, music, and interdisciplinary dialogue.

The challenge is to create an open and inclusive place where cultural excellence is not perceived as elitist, but as a common good available to everyone. In this perspective, Fondazione Meriggio aspires to become a contemporary cultural hub capable of connecting territory, community, institutions, artists, and younger generations

More than simply organizing events, the Foundation seeks to build an environment where ideas, relationships, and new forms of cultural participation can emerge. Its ambition is to contribute to the growth of a vibrant culture capable of engaging with the present without losing touch with its roots.

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2. The Territorial Context: Why Valeggio sul Mincio?

To understand the experience of Fondazione Meriggio, it is essential to begin with the territory in which it operates.

Valeggio sul Mincio is a small town in northern Italy, located in the province of Verona, close to the Lombardy border, a short distance from Lake Garda and near the cities of Verona and Mantua. It

occupies a strategic geographical position along some of Italy's most important transport routes, between Milan and Venice and between the Trentino-Alto Adige region and Emilia-Romagna. Its location makes it easily accessible from a large part of northern Italy.

The area is particularly renowned for its food and wine heritage, especially its winemaking tradition and the famous *tortellini* of Valeggio. It is also home to **Borghetto sul Mincio**, considered one of the most beautiful villages in Italy and a well-established international tourist destination

Yet this strong tourist vocation reveals an important characteristic: most visitors experience the area only briefly, often as a stopover. Those staying around Lake Garda, Verona, or Mantua regularly visit Valeggio for a few hours or a single day. Likewise, many travellers pass through the area while moving between Milan, Venice, the Dolomites, Bologna, and other major destinations in northern Italy.

In this sense, Valeggio is a place that is widely known but rarely experienced in depth

It is precisely within this context that the mission of Fondazione Meriggio takes shape.

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3. Creating a Cultural Hub Where None Existed Before

Fondazione Meriggio was founded on the belief that even a territory located outside major cultural centres can become a place of high-level contemporary cultural production.

In a context traditionally associated with tourism, hospitality, and landscape, the Foundation has chosen to develop a programme centred on contemporary art, philosophy, literature, education, research, and interdisciplinary dialogue

Its goal is not only to provide cultural activities for visitors from abroad or from other Italian regions, but above all to create opportunities for local communities and neighbouring territories

Valeggio sul Mincio is not a large university city, nor a place where many young people build their professional futures. As in many European regions, a significant share of educational and professional opportunities is concentrated in larger urban centres.

The Foundation seeks to contribute to the creation of an alternative: a place where people can encounter ideas, artists, scholars, and internationally renowned professionals without necessarily living in a major metropolis.

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4. A Project Born from a Family Deeply Connected to Its Territory

A fundamental feature of Fondazione Meriggio is its deeply personal character

The Foundation emerged from the vision of Denis Faccioli and Alessandra Pacilli and from their direct connection with this territory.

Rather than being an initiative developed by external investors or institutions observing the territory from afar, it is a project built by people who live here and understand both its potential and its vulnerabilities.

This family-driven dimension is one of the elements that allows the Foundation to maintain authenticity in its approach. The growth of the project is closely linked to a desire to contribute concretely to local cultural development and to give value back to the community.

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5. A Vision Beyond Local Boundaries

Although deeply rooted in its local context, Fondazione Meriggio does not see itself as a purely local project.

Its ambition is to become a cultural point of reference for a much wider area, encompassing Veneto, Lombardy, and the Lake Garda region.

Through a permanent contemporary art collection, philosophical series, literary encounters, conferences, artistic performances, and collaborations with universities, artists, and institutions, the Foundation seeks to build a recognizable and distinctive cultural model.

In other words, its goal is not simply to bring cultural events to the territory, but to create a place distinguished by quality, research, and originality, becoming a unique cultural landmark within the region.

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6. Culture as Investment and Responsibility

Alongside its own activities, the Foundation supports numerous external projects that share values aligned with its mission.

Supporting cultural, artistic, educational, scientific, and social initiatives is one of the ways through which the Foundation seeks to generate a positive impact on both society and the territory

Projects are selected according to qualitative criteria and strong alignment with the Foundation's values. Culture is viewed as a long-term social investment rather than a sponsorship programme.

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7. Putting Young People at the Centre

Perhaps the most significant aspect of territorial regeneration concerns the relationship with younger generations.

One of the Foundation's main objectives is to provide young people with a place for dialogue and cultural exchange that remains both accessible and inclusive.

Fondazione Meriggio believes that quality should not be reserved for a privileged few. It therefore brings distinguished speakers, artists, philosophers, scholars, and professionals to the territory while remaining faithful to its non-profit, educational mission.

Rather than following what is easiest, most immediate, or most popular, the Foundation often chooses to explore challenging and demanding cultural languages, including philosophy, contemporary art, performance art, interdisciplinary dialogue, research, and public engagement.

Its belief is that territories need more than entertainment; they need places capable of elevating public debate, stimulating critical thinking, and generating new forms of cultural participation

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8. Creating Cultural Opportunities, Generating Participation

One of the key questions accompanying the Foundation's birth concerned the relationship between a territory and its cultural demand. Could a place known primarily for tourism, landscape, and

gastronomy sustain a cultural programme that was ambitious, consistent, and intellectually demanding?

The question was straightforward: *Would people actually be interested in philosophical discussions, contemporary art dialogues, experimental performances, and cultural projects that were not immediately commercial?*

The experience of recent years has provided an encouraging answer. Whenever authentic and high-quality opportunities are created, audiences respond. The Foundation's events have demonstrated the existence of a vibrant, curious audience eager for meaningful cultural experiences.

This has led to a crucial insight: communities do not always explicitly express cultural needs before opportunities are offered. Sometimes it is necessary to have the courage to propose, experiment, and create opportunities before they are requested.

For Fondazione Meriggio, culture is not only about organizing events; it is about building an ongoing relationship with audiences and accompanying them towards forms of cultural expression that may initially appear distant or complex.

The goal is therefore twofold: making high-quality culture accessible while gradually fostering a conscious cultural community capable of curiosity, critical thinking, and active participation.

In this perspective, audience development is not simply about attendance figures, but about building a community that recognizes the value of knowledge, dialogue, and beauty.

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9. Authenticity and Cultural Identity

One of the central themes in the European debate on territorial regeneration concerns the risk of turning culture into a mere instrument of tourist attraction. When culture is used exclusively as an economic tool, there is a danger that it loses authenticity and that places end up presenting a simplified version of their identity. [

Fondazione Meriggio follows a different path. Its programme is not designed primarily to increase visitor numbers, but to generate authentic content, meaningful dialogue, and cultural growth opportunities for both the territory and its audiences.

Events, exhibitions, conferences, philosophical programmes, and artistic projects are conceived first and foremost for their cultural value. Only afterwards do they also become attractors for visitors from other areas. In this perspective, audiences are not consumers, but active participants in a cultural process.

For the Foundation, true enhancement means preserving the identity of places while allowing them to continue producing meaning in the present. Authenticity is not a frozen image of the past; it is an ongoing dialogue between memory, community, and contemporary life.

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10. Tradition and Contemporary Culture Are Not Opposites

Many cultural preservation initiatives face a fundamental question: how can identity be preserved without rejecting innovation?

Fondazione Meriggio's experience suggests that tradition and contemporary culture are not opposing forces but can strengthen one another.

Villa Meriggio is a historic residence located within a territory rich in history, local traditions, and landscape heritage. At the same time, it hosts an international contemporary art collection, experimental performances, philosophical discussions, educational projects, and debates on contemporary issues.

The objective is not to replace the past with the present, but to create a dialogue capable of connecting different languages, sensitivities, and generations.

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11. Early Signs of Impact

Although still relatively young, the project has already provided valuable insights into the role a cultural institution can play in a non-metropolitan territory.

The Foundation's initiatives have attracted audiences not only from Valeggio sul Mincio but also from Verona, Mantua, the Lake Garda region, and other parts of Veneto and Lombardy. Participation has proven remarkably diverse in terms of age, background, and origin.

Particularly significant has been the interest shown in activities traditionally considered niche, such as philosophy, contemporary art, literary presentations, and interdisciplinary performances. This suggests that the real obstacle is often not a lack of public interest, but a lack of opportunities.

The growing participation and the return of audiences to subsequent events show how culture can become a lasting part of community life when supported by quality, continuity, and credibility.

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12. A Case Study for Europe

Many of the challenges addressed by Fondazione Meriggio are not uniquely Italian. Across Europe, numerous regions face similar issues: youth outmigration, concentration of opportunities in large cities, transit tourism, difficulties preserving local identities, and the need to develop new forms of participation.

In this sense, the Foundation's experience can be viewed as a small case study illustrating how cultural regeneration can occur without transforming a territory into a standardized tourism product or compromising cultural quality.

Its goal is not to compete with major metropolitan institutions, but to create a complementary model: places deeply rooted in their communities, capable of attracting people through quality, relationships, and authentic heritage.

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13. Lessons Learned

Fondazione Meriggio's experience has generated a number of reflections that may be relevant beyond its immediate context:

- Cultural demand exists even in peripheral territories when meaningful opportunities are offered.
- Accessibility does not require lowering quality or simplifying cultural content.
- Young people respond positively when treated as active participants rather than passive spectators.

- Art and culture can strengthen social cohesion and a sense of belonging.
- Cultural spaces can become meeting points between generations, disciplines, and communities.
- Building an audience requires time, continuity, and trust.
- Culture represents a concrete investment in the future of a territory.
- Participation does not arise solely from responding to existing demand; sometimes it requires the courage to create new opportunities and guide audiences towards them.

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14. Conclusion

The experience of Fondazione Meriggio suggests that cultural regeneration does not necessarily depend on the size of a city or the presence of major institutions. Even a peripheral territory can become a centre of cultural production if there is a clear vision, a strong connection with the community, and a willingness to invest in quality.

The challenge is not simply to preserve existing heritage, but to create places where people, especially young people, can meet, exchange ideas, and imagine the future together.

In this sense, culture is not a complement to territorial development; it is one of its essential conditions.

Fondazione Meriggio's experience demonstrates that even apparently peripheral territories can become generators of cultural innovation, relationships, and new ideas. The real challenge is not to bring culture where it is absent, but to create the conditions for it to be recognized, experienced, and shared by a community.

For this reason, we believe that the future of many European regions may depend not only on economic investment or infrastructure, but also on the creation of places capable of generating meaning, belonging, and opportunities for younger generations. In other words, places where culture is not a consequence of development, but one of its driving forces.